💸 Between the Wars: Reading

World History · Unit 6 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the Global Economic Crisis and Japanese Militarism sheets

Name: _____

Years of Crisis (1919-1939)

Germany paid for World War I mostly by borrowing, expecting to win and make the losers pay. Instead it lost, and the Treaty of Versailles demanded huge reparations. The government printed more and more money to pay its bills. By late 1923, prices doubled every few days. A loaf of bread that cost less than one mark before the war cost about 200 billion marks. People carried cash in wheelbarrows, and children built kites and towers out of bundles of bills. Middle-class families saw their savings wiped out. This is called hyperinflation.

In October 1929, the U.S. stock market crashed. American banks called back loans they had made to Europe, and the Great Depression spread around the world. Factories closed, trade collapsed, and millions lost their jobs. In Germany about 6 million people were unemployed by 1932.

Desperate people looked for strong leaders who promised quick solutions. Benito Mussolini and his Fascist Party took power in Italy in 1922. Adolf Hitler's Nazi Party blamed Germany's problems on the Treaty of Versailles, communists and Jewish people, and Hitler became chancellor in 1933. Both men created totalitarian dictatorships.

Japan, an island nation with few natural resources, wanted an empire to supply oil, iron and rubber. Military leaders gained control of the government. In 1931 Japan invaded Manchuria in northern China and in 1937 began a full war on China. General Hideki Tojo rose through the army and became prime minister in 1941. He led Japan during much of World War II, resigned in 1944 as Japan lost battles, and was tried and executed for war crimes in 1948.

Check your reading

1. Explain what caused hyperinflation in Germany.

2. How did the Great Depression help dictators gain power?

3. Why did Japan's military leaders want to expand?